

Cultural Identity Interview

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Cultural Identity Interview

The goal of this assignment is to explore the intersectionality of various cultural identities and how these identities shape interactions with others. To gain a deeper understanding of these dynamics, I chose to interview someone with whom I share very few personal cultural identities. This approach allows me to appreciate the stark contrasts in how we perceive and interact with the world. Understanding diverse social identities is crucial for promoting empathy, enhancing communication, and informing social justice efforts, all of which contribute to personal growth and the development of inclusive communities. This understanding is also vital for guiding policies and practices in social work settings, where practitioners must navigate needs while considering the complexities of their clients' identities.

The interviewee I selected presents an interesting case for examining the diversity of identities and their interplay. Although we were both born male, I present as feminine and identify as a woman, while they present as masculine and identify as non-binary. Their age difference, being significantly older than me, adds another layer to our discussion. They identify as Jewish, are disabled, and are pansexual. Their disabilities, including a collapsed lung and joint issues, along with mental health challenges such as Dissociative Identity Disorder (DID) and PTSD, are mostly invisible to others, often leading to assumptions about their physical capabilities.

Assumptions

Before the interview, my understanding of them was limited, so like many others, I assumed they were more physically capable based solely on their masculine appearance. This stereotype led me to project traits such as strength and assertiveness onto them. Additionally, the

generational gap between us—I'm part of Gen Z, while they identify as a millennial—led me to make assumptions about their worldview. With over ten years of separation, I expected them to be less forthcoming and perhaps more reserved in sharing their personal experiences. On both accounts I was wrong. Their disabilities, while invisible, affect them quite a bit, making them less physically capable than initially perceived. My assumptions based on their age were also wrong. They shared openly and even enjoyed discussing details about their life.

Identity Breakdown

The interviewee emphasized the significance of their Jewish heritage as a core aspect of their identity. They shared that their experiences with DID, as well as their gender and sexual orientation, have become increasingly pronounced, especially given the current sociopolitical climate. While they hold their Jewish identity dear, their disabilities often remain unseen, leading to misconceptions about their physical capabilities. They acknowledge the privileges that come with their whiteness and masculine presentation, particularly in the context of living in the South. However, they also face challenges, including antisemitic comments and violence due to their vocal Jewish identity, and misunderstandings arising from their gender expression, particularly in interactions with women. Despite being raised in an upper-middle-class family, they have experienced a shift to lower-class status over the past decade, although they still rely on their family as a safety net when necessary. Overall, they describe a worldview shaped by openness and acceptance, values instilled in them through their Jewish upbringing, which often contrasts with the experiences of their peers.

Race

The interviewee acknowledges that their whiteness affords them certain privileges, allowing them to navigate many spaces with a level of ease that individuals from marginalized racial backgrounds may not experience. However, they also emphasize that their Jewish identity is multifaceted, encompassing both ethnic and religious dimensions. This duality complicates their understanding of their racial identity, as they have encountered heightened antisemitism when they disclose this aspect of themselves. While their white appearance may grant them access to certain societal advantages, it also masks the discrimination they face due to their Jewish heritage.

Sex and Gender

Though they were assigned male at birth and often present as masculine, they identify as non-binary and do not actively seek to conform to any specific gender expression. This perceived masculinity has led to communication challenges, as some people approach them with caution. Raised with the belief that being genuine is essential, they assumed others shared this value, only to find that their expression sometimes led to misunderstandings or controversy.

Sexual Orientation

Identifying as pansexual, the interviewee embraces the potential to love individuals regardless of their gender identity. Their upbringing fostered acceptance of diverse identities, which extends to their own and informs their loving relationships. They also identify as polyamorous, embracing the idea that their capacity for love is not limited to one person but can be shared with multiple partners.

Social Status and Class

Raised in an upper-middle-class environment, they enjoyed certain privileges. However, over the past 15 years, they have faced financial hardships and are currently lower-class. Despite this shift, they still have the benefit of family support, which they consider a last resort.

Religion

Religion plays a central role in their life, with their Jewish identity being the most significant aspect of their cultural self. Although religion is not always visible, they openly express its importance and consider it foundational to who they are. As part of their upbringing they were raised with an open mind and with the values of accepting everyone.

Ability and Disability

The interviewee navigates the challenges posed by a collapsed lung and worsening joint issues, which complicate their interactions with the world. Additionally, their experience with DID shapes their identity and results in unique social interactions, while PTSD—stemming from military service—often manifests in response to loud noises, such as fireworks.

Age

At 36 years old, they rarely consider their age, except in contexts involving others, such as social gatherings or professional settings where age might play a role in how individuals relate to one another. This tendency suggests that their age holds little significance in their self-perception and identity. They feel comfortable in their own skin and often prioritize personal experiences, accomplishments, and relationships over the numerical marker of age. For them,

age is not a defining characteristic, and they focus more on the present moment and future possibilities rather than dwelling on the past or societal expectations associated with getting older.

Awareness

In terms of self-awareness, they noted that DID and their Jewish identity are at the forefront, followed closely by considerations of their abilities, which affect them daily. Their sexual orientation and gender are less frequently brought to mind, but are still important to their identity. They consider their age to be largely unimportant to them.

Responses to Triggers

When confronted with triggers, their primary response is to ignore and avoid them, unless they feel actively threatened. This coping strategy reflects their approach to navigating the complexities of their intersecting identities.

Critical Incident

The interviewee chose to reflect on a moment where they felt proud and nurtured by their membership in a social group. First, they again discussed their deep connection to their Jewish identity, expressing that participating in traditions—whether it be celebrating holidays, engaging in community gatherings, or simply sharing meals with others who share the same cultural background—brings them great joy. The sense of belonging they feel within the Jewish community is profound, as it fosters an environment of mutual support and understanding. They also gave a second example, which was their experience at a local pride event in Greenville. Having recently moved to South Carolina, they noted that they hadn't had the opportunity to

attend pride festivals in the area before. As such, they were initially uncertain about what to expect from this event, given the trend of local poliics. To their delight, it turned out to be a much larger and more vibrant celebration than they had anticipated. The turnout was impressive, and the energy of the crowd was infectious. This event not only made them feel welcomed and included within the local LGBTQ+ community, but it also reinforced their sense of pride in their identity.

Identity Wheel

